

Tiles and reading order, overlaid on the page

1 **George Purnell Gunn** (October 11, 1903 – June 18, 1973) was an American prelate who served as the 18th **Episcopal Bishop of Southern Virginia** between 1950 and 1971.

3 **Early life and education**

Gunn was born on October 11, 1903, in [Winona, Mississippi](#), the son of Rev. Elijah Sterling Gunn and Susan Ellwood Carter. Based on his parents' ancestry, Gunn later became active with the [First Families of Virginia](#). Raised in [Halifax County, Virginia](#),^[1] young George attended at the [Virginia Episcopal School](#) in [Lynchburg](#) between 1921 and 1923. In 1924 he went to [Charlottesville](#) for studies at the [University of Virginia](#), graduating with a [Bachelor of Arts](#) in 1927. He then traveled to [Alexandria](#) to study for the ministry at the [Virginia Theological Seminary](#), graduating in 1930. The same institution awarded him a [Doctor of Divinity](#) in 1946. He married Frances Hawkins Purnell on September 3, 1930, and together had three children.^[2]

4 **Ministry**

Bishop [Robert Carter Jett](#) of the [Episcopal Diocese of Southwestern Virginia](#) ordained Gunn as a deacon in October 1929 and priest in June 1930. He then became rector of [Moore Parish](#) in [Altavista, Campbell County, Virginia](#). In 1932 he left that position and traveled to the eastern part of the Commonwealth to become rector of the Church of the Good Shepherd in [Norfolk, Virginia](#), where he remained till 1948.^[3]

5 **Bishop**

Gunn was elected Coadjutor Bishop of Southern Virginia on September 17, 1947, during a diocesan special convention called by bishop [William A. Brown](#), who planned to retire in several years after training his successor.^[4] He was consecrated on January 6, 1948, by Presiding Bishop [Henry Knox Sherrill](#) in a ceremony also attended by many Episcopal bishops. Rt.Rev. Gunn then succeeded as diocesan bishop on January 6, 1950, when Bishop Brown retired. Bishop Gunn continued fulfilling his pastoral and administrative duties as bishop of the diocese with many historic churches as well as booming populations due to military expansion in its Hampton Roads area until his own retirement in 1971. He died in [Norfolk, Virginia](#), on June 18, 1973.

6 **References**

- ↑ "St. John's Episcopal Church, Halifax, Virginia: History".
- ↑ White, T. J. (1980). "Gunn, George Purnell". *The National Cyclopaedia of American Biography*. **99**: 212.
- ↑ "George Purnell Gunn". *The Monthly Supplement*. 497. 1951.
- ↑ "Mr. Gunn Elected Coadjutor of Southern Virginia". *The Living Church*. **115** (13): 3. 26 September 1947.

7 [Winona, 1913 census](#) | [1900 birth](#) | [People from Winona, Mississippi](#) | [People from Halifax County, Virginia](#) | [University of Virginia alumni](#) | [Virginia Theological Seminary alumni](#) | [20th-century American Episcopal priests](#) | [Episcopal Bishops of Southern Virginia](#)

The Right Reverend George Purnell Gunn D.D. Bishop of Southern Virginia

Church Episcopal Church Diocese Southern Virginia In office 1950–1971 Predecessor William A. Brown Successor David Rose Previous post Coadjutor Bishop of Southern Virginia (1948–1949)
Orders
Ordination June 1930 by Robert Carter Jett
Consecration January 6, 1948 by Henry Knox Sherrill
Personal details
Born October 11, 1903 Winona, Mississippi
Died June 18, 1973 (aged 69) Norfolk, Virginia
Denomination Anglican
Parents Elijah Sterling Gunn & Susan Ellwood Carter
Spouse Frances Hawkins Purnell (m. 1930)
Children 3
Alma mater University of Virginia

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